not amenable to the concepts of boundaries or lines that nation states are built upon.

India's extended Central Asian neighbourhood is an ethnic jigsaw bearing overlapping footprints of the world's major religions – Hinduism, Buddhism, Islam and even Zoroastrianism. The great city of Bukhara derives its name from the Sanskrit word *vihara* and the large number of Buddhist monasteries it housed. It is also through Central Asia that Indian mathematical treatises, medicine systems and astronomy travelled to the Arab world, and later to Europe. [8] In addition, India still bears the imprint of its Mughal emperors who came from Central Asia in the fifteenth century CE .

Like India, this mountain region too is home to a veritable crossroads culture that cannot be easily uprooted.

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At its height, the British Indian empire inherited the historical and cultural legacy that bound India to its extended neighbourhood. Delhi ruled from Aden in the west to Singapore in the east on behalf of London, and sought to safeguard northern India from the threatening advance of the Russian empire. Indian currency, particularly the silver rupee, was in use across this neighbourhood. When I visited the ancient caravan town of Kashgar in Chinese Xinjiang in 1984, the silversmiths in the older part of the town still carried a large hoard of Indian silver rupees, which had been the preferred medium of exchange even in the early 1950s.

It is likely that as India's economic and security capabilities increase, its influence will expand into the extended neighbourhood of the past, along the remembered pathways of its old crossroads encounters. Throughout history India was a remarkably cosmopolitan place with diverse ethnicities, religions and cultures. And its embrace of plurality is not contrived. This makes the Indian remarkably adaptable, at ease in the world and accepting of its diversity. Maybe this is the Indian diaspora's secret of success. Twenty-first-century India's acceptance of globalization, though still